

Star-Ledger Sports

14★★ NEWARK, N. J., MONDAY, MAY 30, 1960



Sports Desk

By JOE DIETZ

Andy Cohen looks back . . .

Scrappy Andy Cohen stroked his sharp chin one night last week in the Philly dugout at Connie Mack Stadium.

"How would John McGraw make out as a big league manager today?" he repeated. "That's an interesting question. In everybody's book, McGraw was one of the greatest of all managers, even when stacked up against such successful fellows of today as Casey Stengel.

"There is no doubt he would be just as successful as when I played for him with the old Giants. But there can be no doubt that if he were managing today he wouldn't be the same McGraw exactly.

"He would have to change his tactics. He would recognize he was handling a different kind of player and would be smart enough to adjust himself to the new conditions. Yes, I'm sure he would make the grade today."

Cohen, back in baseball as a Philadelphia coach after a year's layoff at his home in Texas, will be remembered as the man selected to succeed second baseman Rogers Hornsby after McGraw traded the old Rajah away in the mid twenties. McGraw hoped the 18-year-old Cohen would bring his Jewish admirers in droves to the Polo Grounds when the Giants were suffering at the gate due to the presence of Babe Ruth in Yankee Stadium, across the Harlem.

The strategy was eminently successful, for a while at least. Andy's bat set the league on fire, but eventually the adoration of the fans and their social demands wore down Cohen and McGraw sold him to the Newark Bears in 1929.

Some good Sunday drinkers

"McGraw," Andy recalled, "was a strict disciplinarian. He had to be in those days when ballplayers were known for their drinking and helling around.

"Every morning he made them report at the ballpark at 10 o'clock on the dot and woe betide anybody who was late. And there was an 11 o'clock bedcheck every night—hell, we used to be in bed long before ballplayers now leave the ballpark. But of, course, we played only day games.

"But one thing about the old timers. They could carouse with the best of them but they were always ready to play. They were they seldom blamed the manager.

punished only when they were caught and when they got caught

"There are disciplinary problems a manager has to face today, but they can't compare with those of McGraw's day. But he knew just how to handle everybody and get the best baseball possible out of them.

"He was smart enough, too, not to tamper with a player's style. When Mel Ott, for instance, came up the same time I did in 1926—he was just 16—McGraw kept him on the bench for a year just sitting around learning. He could have sent him to the minors but he was afraid they would change his batting style, make him stop raising that leg as he stepped into the ball.

"Strategy?" Oh, I guess he didn't do the basic things any different than we do them today. His techniques depended on the type of club he had. If he had a team of long ball hitters he would play for the big inning.

"If he had top pitching and good defense, he'd play for one run. That's pretty much what we do today."

Getting back to Old Jawn's method of coping with individual personalities.

"Well," replied Andy, "McGraw had a knack of handling each player in just the right way. If a player was a high-type sort of guy, McGraw never jumped him too much. He never said much to Pancho Snyder, the great catcher, because he knew Snyder was big and tough and would break a leg to follow orders.

Never rode 'High Pockets'

"He never rode George (High Pockets) Kelly too much but he did give it to Frankie Frisch and Freddy Lindstrom. He respected Bill Terry even though he didn't like him because he was the head-strong type, the master of his own destiny.

"His favorite ballplayers? Carl Hubbell would have to be right

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